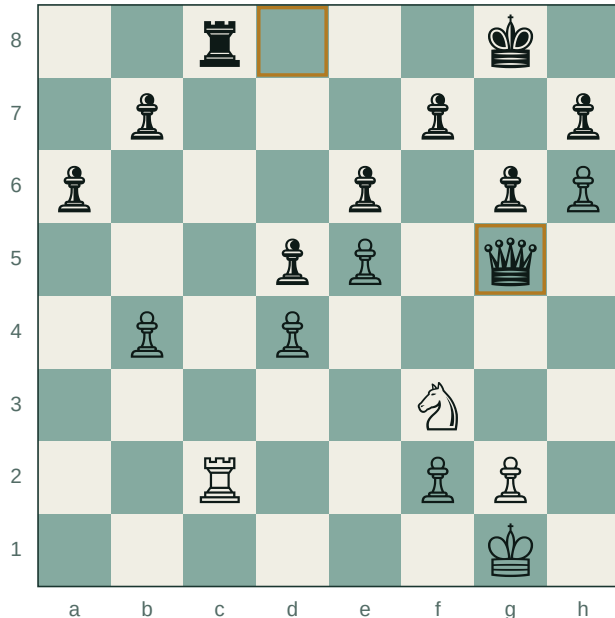


Loose-piece tactics: White, move 40

Loose-piece tactics

White to move



Previous move: 39...Qxg5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

40. Rxc8+ Qd8 41. Rxd8#

40.Rxc8+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. The move also takes the rook on c8. Recorded reply: **40...Qd8**.

41.Rxd8# Mate: rook on d8 gives check; Black has no legal reply.

The line ends in checkmate against the king on g8. Material gain is unnecessary once no legal defense exists.

CHECKPOINT

Which piece delivers the final check, and why can the defender not continue? **Answer:** Rook on d8. The king is in check and the position has zero legal replies.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on g8. Geometrically undefended: rook on c8 and queen on g5. Check for tactical protection.